

LOUD AND CLEAR A protest demanding the seer's arrest in Bengaluru

The matha also runs over a hundred institutions, including engineering and medical colleges besides polytechnics, schools and hostels for disabled and orphaned children. "Some 3,000 visitors are fed here daily. On the 5th of every month, we also conduct mass marriages at the matha," says a follower. Sharanaru is an extremely influential figure, with top politicians such as the BJP's Amit Shah and the Congress's Rahul Gandhi calling on him over the years. Indeed, just last month, he was in the news for presenting an *ishtalinga* (a small *linga* worn around the neck on a thread) to Rahul by way of a rite of initiation known as *linga deekshe*. When the sexual abuse scandal broke, the BJP's veteran Lingayat leader and ex-chief minister B.S. Yediyurappa and a few seers spoke up in his support. Sharanaru has considerable goodwill among religious leaders from the Dalit and backward caste groups in Chitradurga, whom he has mentored. Even so, Dalit organisations had staged a protest demanding his arrest, and also filed a separate case under the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, as one of the girls was from a Dalit community.

It all started on August 26 when Mysuru-based NGO Odanadi Seva Samsthe approached the district child welfare committee there with the two victims. Subsequently, an FIR was registered and the case was transferred to Chitradurga since the alleged crimes took place there. Odanadi says the girls left the hostel sometime in July and had somehow made their way to Bengaluru. Here, they were noticed by an autorickshaw driver who took them to the police station. The local cops apparently got in touch with the matha administration following which some representatives, including one of the guardians, came to take the girls back. "We came to know only on August 26. That's the first time I met the victims," says K.V. Stanly, co-founder of Odanadi, which works with victims of sexual abuse and trafficking. The NGO was informed about the girls over the phone a day earlier and their trip to Mysuru was arranged by the wife of the then matha administrator, S.K. Basavarajan, says Stanly. The pontiff claims the case is a conspiracy to malign him. The matha has removed Basavarajan from the administrator's position. The latter also now faces a rape charge, made by an employee who is a co-accused in the POCSO (Protection of Children from Sexual Offences) Act charges against the seer.

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At the matha, some of the elderly folk betray a sense of confusion and dejection. "This is a black mark on our matha," says a senior member of the laity, requesting anonymity. On September 3, when the seer was being questioned by the police in Chitradurga town, well-wishers were still trickling in to the matha whose main entrance leads into a stone vestibule, said to have been built by Chitradurga's 18th century heroic chieftain Madakari Nayaka. The stone steps lead to a large wood-panelled room on the upper floor with the pontiff's seat at the centre of it. Beyond this are his personal quarters.

Basavarajan, an ex-MLA from Chitradurga, is an old protégé of the matha, like the pontiff. Hailing from neighbouring villages, the two joined the institution the same year, 1973—Sharanaru was a pre-university student at the time and Basavarajan was in Class VIII. Years later, the latter rose to become administrator while Sharanaru was anointed pontiff in 1991. Apparently, they fell out in 2007 following which Basavarajan was evicted from the matha. The civil cases filed against him at the time are still ongoing, he points out. This March, however, after 15 years in exile, Basavarajan came back to the matha as administrator. "It's all internal politics," says the matha follower cited earlier. "Why he came back and what happened after that, nobody knows." Basavarajan denies the insinuations, saying it's only natural for the seer's supporters to react in this manner. "The pontiff is the sole trustee, and his word is final," says Basavarajan, in response to charges of a tussle for control. "I went back unconditionally."

The allegation against Sharanaru is that the girls, who were staying in a hostel on the campus, were repeatedly molested and even beaten with sticks. Four others, including the hostel warden and a junior seer, Basavaditya—who was recently named the pontiff's successor—are named in the FIR as abettors. The two victims come from difficult circumstances, one of them is an orphan and the other has no mother, points out Stanly. "How the children came (to us), who brought them is not an issue," he says, stressing on the need for an impartial investigation. State home minister Araga Jnanendra says the police have been given a free hand, but the NGO feels the case must be transferred out of the state to ensure a fair probe. ■